

This transformation created favourable conditions for the turtles.

The story of Rushikulya as a premier nesting site for Olive Ridleys dates back to March 1994, when marine turtle researcher Bivash Pandav, now a scientist at the Wildlife Institute of India, first documented mass nesting there. Two years later, the Odisha Forest Department took the site under its protective wing.

Today, a 20-km stretch from Aryapalli to Prayagi has been identified as a probable nesting zone, with a 10-km core area declared a no-fishing zone from November to May, since turtles fall prey to trawling nets, gill nets and fishing hooks. To support around 8,000 affected fishing families, the government provides a one-time compensation of Rs 15,000. A 5-km high-probability nesting zone between Ghokarakuda and Bateswar village receives special attention. The census of nesting turtles has a methodology. The five-km zone is divided into 50 segments of 100 metres each. At the middle, a 20-metre section is selected, where incoming turtles are counted hourly and marked with ink. This data is then used to estimate the total number of nesting turtles.

Since Rushikulya is a dynamic beach, constantly shaped by erosion and accretion, maintaining its suitability for nesting needs vigilance. The forest and fisheries departments and the marine police jointly patrol the waters. A 240-member strong turtle protection squad works through the nesting season, ensuring the safety of the turtles and their eggs.

Dr Basudev Tripathy, member of the Marine Turtle Specialist Group at the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), says that changes in nesting behaviour may be linked to environmental shifts. "The decline of other habitats may have driven a larger number of turtles to Rushikulya this year. The Devi river mouth in Puri, once one of the three major nesting sites in Odisha alongside Rushikulya and Gahirmatha, has seen a drop in numbers due to increasing disturbances," he explains.

Tripathy elaborates on the global implications. "The population of Olive Ridleys in the Indian Ocean is distinct from those in the Atlantic or Pacific. While an increase in numbers here does not necessarily indicate an overall rise in the species worldwide, it is a promising sign. The IUCN is debating whether to downgrade Olive Ridleys from an 'endangered' to a 'vulnerable' species," Tripathy adds.

Pandav agrees, noting that fluctuations in numbers are natural. "It's not unusual for turtles to skip nesting at a particular beach, like Rushikulya last year," he says. However, he speculates that this year's record numbers may be a response to environmental factors yet to be fully understood.

As conservationists celebrate this year's historic 'arribada', their message remains clear: the battle to protect Olive Ridleys is far from over. This year's success serves as a reminder of the delicate balance between nature and conservation—one that must be maintained if these ancient mariners are to thrive in future. ■

ANCIENT MARINERS IN ODISHA

- **Olive Ridleys are sea turtles found in the Atlantic, Pacific and Indian Oceans and get their name from their olive-green carapace**
- **They are a fundamental link in marine ecosystems and help maintain the health of coral reefs and sea grass beds**
- **From mid-February and through March, Rushikulya beach in Odisha witnessed a mass nesting event, with 698,718 Olive Ridleys laying eggs; last year, there were no turtles**
- **Nearby Gahirmatha beach recorded 606,933 turtles**
- **This is due to sustained conservation efforts, favourable climate and proactive management like fishing restrictions and beach clean-ups**
- **The forest and fisheries departments and marine police jointly patrol the waters thrice a day during the nesting season**